society and community need unity,' he said. 'That is the only purpose.'[10] The monk diplomatically avoided the question of whether Lingayat voters should support the BJP or the Congress.

T.B. Shekhar of the Veerashaiva Samaj was proven right when the results were declared. The BJP emerged as the single largest party in the polls. Its lead was powered by wins in a majority of the seventy assembly seats where Lingayat voters were dominant (over 15 per cent of voters).[11] The 2018 Karnataka election initiated a year of messy coalition-building and changing governments, but the Tumkur factor also underscored the vast tonal contrast between politics in the Hindi heartland and south of the Vindhya ranges—the traditional boundary between north and south India.

Presaging the BJP: Lingayats, Vokkaligas and Karnataka's Changing 'Dominant' Caste Patterns

The political attendance at the Siddaganga Math underscores the changing 'dominant caste'—to use a term coined by the sociologist M.N. Srinivas in 1959[12]—politics in Karnataka. The Ekikaran (Unification) movement had led to Kannada-speaking regions from the adjoining states of Madras, Hyderabad and Bombay being incorporated into the old princely state of Mysore. Before this reorganisation in 1956, Vokkaligas, a land-owning farming community, were the biggest caste in Mysore. The Congress's Lingayat leaders had led the demand for Karnataka's unification and came to constitute the largest caste community in the enlarged state. Lingayats also formed a major support base for the party in the non-Mysore regions of the new state.[13]

By way of background, while the Lingayat lineage goes back to the twelfth century, they were first listed as a caste within Hinduism in the Mysore state's 1881 Census[14] and first referred to as a 'sect' in 1928 by the scholar R.G. Bhandarkar. The community's unique religious attributes—the wearing of an Ishtalinga (a symbol of Shiva) on the body, strict vegetarianism, rejection of temple worship, the substitution of Brahmins with their own priests in life-death ceremonies, their rejection of the caste system and their practice of